

Defensive Reconstruction

How Compressed Architectures
Rewrite Accessible Reality

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Contents

Defensive Reconstruction: How Compressed Architectures Rewrite Accessible Reality	3
Abstract	3
1. Introduction: The Gap Between Compression and Distortion	3
1.1 Scope Boundary	4
2. Theoretical Foundation	4
2.1 Compression Recap	4
2.2 Representational Cost	4
2.3 The Threshold Condition	4
2.4 Compression vs Reconstruction: The Core Distinction	5
3. Defensive Reconstruction	5
3.1 Definition and Mechanism	5
3.2 Neutral Reconstruction vs Defensive Reconstruction	5
3.3 The Reconstruction Sequence	6
3.4 Why Reconstruction Is Not Conscious Deception	6
3.5 Why Reconstructed Reality Feels Subjectively Real	6
3.6 Implications for Confrontation and Clinical Engagement	7
4. Directionality of Reconstruction	7
4.1 Reconstruction Follows Compression Topology	7
4.2 Self-Architecture Stakes Determine Direction	7
4.3 Domain-Specific Reconstruction Patterns	8
4.4 Prediction: Intra-Individual Domain Specificity	8
5. Feedback Integration Capacity	9
5.1 Definition	9
5.2 Multi-Stage Process	9
5.3 The Recursive Feedback Trap	9
5.4 FIC as Partially Independent from IRC	9
5.5 Therapy as FIC-Enabling Condition	10
6. Structural Opacity	10
6.1 Definition	10
6.2 Opacity as Derived Consequence	10
6.3 Why Updating Fails Phenomenologically	11
6.4 Signal-Class Specificity of Opacity	11
6.5 Self-Report Unreliability in Opaque Domains	11
6.6 Opacity-FIC Interaction Matrix	11
7. Relationship to Existing Literature	12
7.1 Motivated Reasoning	12
7.2 Cognitive Dissonance	12
7.3 Reconstructive Memory	12
7.4 Self-Deception Literature	13
7.5 Explicit Novelty Claims	13
8. Predictions and Testability	13
8.1 Reconstruction Direction Follows Compression Profile	13
8.2 Self-Other Discrepancy Is Domain-Specific	13
8.3 FIC Predicts Therapy Responsiveness	14
8.4 Collapse Progression Is Sequential	14
8.5 Candidate Measurement Approaches	14

9. Collapse Progression: From Selective Compression to Ontological Binary Encoding	14
9.1 Stage 1: Selective Compression	14
9.2 Stage 2: Cross-Domain Coupling	15
9.3 Stage 3: Signal-Class Convergence	15
9.4 Stage 4: Ontological Binary Encoding	15
9.5 Clinical Examples	15
10. Clinical Implications	16
10.1 Why Confrontation Fails	16
10.2 Scaffolded Integration vs Forced Insight	16
10.3 Collapse Prevention vs Collapse Recovery	16
10.4 Therapeutic Alliance as FIC-Enabling Condition	17
11. Limitations	17
11.1 Empirical Status	17
11.2 Boundary with Motivated Cognition Literature	17
11.3 Opacity Measurement Paradox	17
11.4 FIC Independence Question	17
11.5 Collapse Progression: Sequential or Parallel?	18
11.6 Generalizability	18
12. Conclusion	18
References	18

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Abstract

The Structural Regulation Framework (SRF; Halmetoja, 2026a) proposes that psychological regulation operates through signal-class-specific compression of representational resolution. Papers 1-6 of the SRF theory program formalize how compression reduces the fidelity with which psychologically meaningful signals can be processed. However, compression alone may not fully account for clinical phenomena in which reality appears not merely simplified but actively reorganized in regulatory-serving directions. This paper proposes defensive reconstruction as a distinct second-order process: when the representational cost of maintaining higher-fidelity integration exceeds current holding capacity within an activated signal domain, the system may reshape accessible subjective reality to preserve regulatory coherence. This is not merely seeing less - it is seeing something else. The paper formalizes the distinction between compression and reconstruction, introduces Feedback Integration Capacity and Structural Opacity as derived constructs, proposes a four-stage collapse progression model culminating in Ontological Binary Encoding, and articulates explicit predictions and measurement approaches. SRF does not claim that all psychological distortion emerges from compression. It proposes one specific subtype: domain-selective defensive reconstruction under representational overload.

1. Introduction: The Gap Between Compression and Distortion

The first-generation SRF architecture (Halmetoja, 2026a, 2026b, 2026c, 2026d, 2026e, 2026f) establishes a layered explanatory framework for psychological regulation. Paper 1 defines the regulatory mechanism. Paper 2 explains why regulatory structures resist change. Paper 3 applies the framework to narcissistic organization. Paper 4 introduces signal-class-specific compression profiles. Paper 5 formalizes self-architecture as the vulnerability topology that determines which signal classes become threatening. Paper 6 extends the analysis to ontological regulation, where continuity of being itself becomes the protected target.

Across this architecture, compression serves as the primary explanatory mechanism: representational resolution decreases under activation, producing simplified, categorical, or minimally differentiated processing within threatened signal domains.

However, clinical observation suggests that compression alone may not fully account for certain phenomena. In some presentations, reality does not merely become low-resolution. It appears to become specifically reorganized in directions that serve regulatory stability. Ambiguous interpersonal events may gradually transform into persecution narratives. Neutral feedback may be reinterpreted as malicious attack. Complex relational dynamics may be reshaped into simplified accounts that preserve self-coherence at the expense of representational fidelity.

This paper proposes that these phenomena may reflect a distinct second-order process: defensive reconstruction.

The central question is not whether memory and perception are reconstructive - modern cognitive science already establishes this (Bartlett, 1932; Schacter, 1996; Loftus, 2005). The question is:

Why do certain minds reconstruct certain experiences in certain directions?

SRF proposes that the answer may lie in signal-class-specific compression topology and self-architecture stakes.

1.1 Scope Boundary

This paper does not claim that all psychological distortion emerges from compression or reconstruction. Human cognition produces distortion through many mechanisms: heuristic processing, schema-driven inference, attentional limitations, emotional salience effects, and ordinary reconstructive memory processes.

SRF proposes one specific subtype: domain-selective defensive reconstruction under representational overload. This subtype is hypothesized to be distinguishable from general cognitive bias by its structural specificity - it follows compression topology and self-architecture stakes rather than operating uniformly across domains.

2. Theoretical Foundation

2.1 Compression Recap

Compression, as formalized in Paper 4 (Halmetoja, 2026d), refers to the defensive reduction in representational resolution within a signal class under activation. Compression is structural rather than random - it follows the topology of self-architecture vulnerabilities. A person may maintain high representational resolution in professional domains while operating under severe compression in dependency or shame-related signal classes.

Compression produces several consequences: - Nuance becomes difficult to maintain - Contradiction collapses into categorical processing - Ambiguity narrows toward threat-consistent interpretation - Affective complexity simplifies

These consequences are well-established within the first-generation architecture. However, they describe resolution loss - not resolution replacement.

2.2 Representational Cost

This paper introduces representational cost as a formalization of the psychological expense of maintaining higher-fidelity integration within a given signal domain.

Representational cost is not random. It depends on: - Signal class (which domain is activated) - Self-architecture stakes (what is threatened - affect, identity, or continuity of being) - Current regulatory capacity (available IRC) - Shame load within the domain - Dependency intolerance - Contradiction sensitivity

A representation becomes functionally unsustainable when its maintenance cost exceeds available holding capacity within the activated signal domain.

2.3 The Threshold Condition

The proposed threshold condition for defensive reconstruction is:

Representational cost of higher-fidelity integration > current IRC within the activated signal domain

When this threshold is exceeded, the system faces a regulatory dilemma: maintaining accurate representation destabilizes self-coherence, but the resulting gap in coherent self-narrative also produces instability.

This dilemma may drive the transition from compression (passive resolution loss) to reconstruction (active regulatory replacement).

2.4 Compression vs Reconstruction: The Core Distinction

Compression and reconstruction are proposed as distinct processes:

Compression: Passive reduction in representational resolution. The system loses the capacity to differentiate nuance within a signal domain. The result is simplified, categorical processing. Compression produces gaps.

Reconstruction: Active regulatory replacement of lost or unsustainable representational content. The system fills gaps with interpretation that preserves regulatory coherence. The result is not merely simplified reality but specifically reshaped reality.

Analogy (heuristic only): Compression is analogous to image resolution loss - detail disappears. Reconstruction is analogous to AI-generated infill - the system produces plausible content to replace what was lost, but the generated content serves the system's requirements rather than representing the original signal.

3. Defensive Reconstruction

3.1 Definition and Mechanism

Defensive reconstruction is defined as the regulatory reshaping of accessible subjective reality when the representational cost of maintaining higher-fidelity integration exceeds current holding capacity within an activated signal domain.

The proposed mechanism operates through the following sequence:

1. A psychologically meaningful event occurs
2. The event activates a signal domain with high self-architecture stakes
3. Higher-fidelity representation of the event would require integration of threatening content (shame, dependency, vulnerability, contradiction)
4. The representational cost of this integration exceeds available IRC
5. Compression reduces initial resolution (passive process)
6. The resulting low-resolution representation contains gaps and instability
7. The system reconstructs coherent meaning from the compressed material
8. Reconstruction direction is constrained by compression topology and self-architecture stakes
9. The reconstructed interpretation becomes accessible subjective reality

3.2 Neutral Reconstruction vs Defensive Reconstruction

Not all reconstruction is defensive. Human cognition routinely fills gaps using schemas, expectations, and narrative continuity. This is ordinary reconstructive memory processing (Bartlett, 1932; Schacter, 1996).

Defensive reconstruction is distinguished by: - **Stakes sensitivity:** Direction is shaped by self-architecture vulnerabilities - **Domain selectivity:** Occurs preferentially within compressed signal classes - **Regulatory**

function: The reconstructed content specifically preserves self-coherence - **Resistance to updating:** Reconstructed content resists correction because correction would reactivate the original representational overload

Neutral reconstruction fills gaps with schema-consistent content. Defensive reconstruction fills gaps with regulatory-serving content.

3.3 The Reconstruction Sequence

The full sequence from event to reconstructed reality may involve multiple temporal stages:

Encoding stage: High-threat activation produces compression during initial processing. The event is encoded at reduced representational resolution. Nuance, contradiction, and the other's perspective may never be fully integrated.

Storage stage: The compressed memory trace persists as structurally incomplete representation. Gaps exist where higher-fidelity content was never successfully encoded.

Retrieval stage: When the memory is accessed - particularly under continued regulatory pressure - the system encounters gaps and instability in the stored representation.

Reconstruction stage: The system fills gaps and resolves instability by generating coherent interpretation. This interpretation is constrained by current compression topology and self-architecture stakes.

Consolidation stage: The reconstructed version may gradually replace the original compressed trace, becoming the primary accessible representation of the event.

3.4 Why Reconstruction Is Not Conscious Deception

A critical distinction must be maintained between defensive reconstruction and conscious deception.

Conscious deception: Higher-fidelity representation exists and is accessible to the individual. The individual intentionally presents an altered version while retaining access to the more accurate representation.

Defensive reconstruction: Higher-fidelity representation is unavailable, unstable, or functionally intolerable. The reconstructed version is not experienced as fabrication - it is experienced as reality. The individual does not have stable access to a "truer" version that they are concealing.

This distinction has profound clinical implications. Confrontation strategies that assume conscious deception may fail precisely because the individual is not protecting a known lie. They may be protecting the only psychologically survivable version of reality currently accessible to the system.

3.5 Why Reconstructed Reality Feels Subjectively Real

This may be the most clinically important aspect of defensive reconstruction.

Reconstructed content does not typically feel fabricated, uncertain, or provisional to the individual. It feels real. It carries phenomenological certainty. The individual may defend their reconstructed version with genuine conviction because, from inside the architecture, it is the only accessible version of events.

Several factors may contribute to this phenomenological certainty:

Opacity: The compression that preceded reconstruction is itself invisible from inside (see Section 7). The individual cannot perceive that their representational resolution was reduced, and therefore cannot perceive that reconstruction occurred.

Coherence: The reconstructed version resolves the instability that gaps would produce. It feels coherent, complete, and internally consistent - which the original compressed trace did not.

Emotional congruence: The reconstructed version aligns with the individual's current emotional state and regulatory needs. It feels emotionally true even if representationally inaccurate.

Absence of alternative: If higher-fidelity representation was never successfully encoded or has become inaccessible, there is no competing version to create doubt. The reconstructed version is not chosen over alternatives - it is the only version available.

Repetition effects: Each retrieval may strengthen the reconstructed version through reconsolidation, making it progressively more stable and subjectively certain over time.

This explains why individuals may pass polygraph tests, show genuine emotional distress when disbelieved, and maintain their version with unwavering conviction. They are not performing. They are reporting their accessible reality.

3.6 Implications for Confrontation and Clinical Engagement

If reconstructed reality carries genuine phenomenological certainty, then confrontation-based approaches face a fundamental structural problem.

Confrontation assumes: "You know the truth but are avoiding it."

Defensive reconstruction suggests: "The truth may not be stably accessible within the current architecture."

This does not mean that all self-reports are equally valid or that external reality is irrelevant. It means that the pathway to more accurate representation may require increasing holding capacity before higher-fidelity content can be tolerated - not merely presenting evidence that the current version is inaccurate.

4. Directionality of Reconstruction

4.1 Reconstruction Follows Compression Topology

SRF does not propose that defensive reconstruction produces random distortion. The direction of reconstruction is hypothesized to follow the individual's compression topology (Paper 4; Halmetoja, 2026d) and self-architecture stakes (Paper 5; Halmetoja, 2026e).

This is the central novelty claim of the present paper: reconstruction is architecturally constrained. The same ambiguous event may be reconstructed differently by different individuals depending on which signal classes are compressed and which self-architecture dimensions are threatened.

4.2 Self-Architecture Stakes Determine Direction

Paper 5 (Halmetoja, 2026e) formalizes seven dimensions of self-architecture that determine vulnerability topology. When representational overload triggers reconstruction, the direction of reshaping may be constrained by whichever self-architecture dimension carries the highest stakes:

- **Worth contingency:** Reconstruction may reshape events to preserve worth-relevant interpretations
- **Shame integration capacity:** Low shame integration may drive reconstruction toward externalization (the problem is in others, not in self)

- **Dependency tolerance:** Low dependency tolerance may drive reconstruction toward independence-preserving narratives
- **Self-other differentiation:** Poor differentiation may drive reconstruction toward merger or persecution interpretations
- **Ontological self-continuity:** Threatened continuity may drive reconstruction toward existence-confirming interpretations

4.3 Domain-Specific Reconstruction Patterns

Based on the interaction between compression topology and self-architecture stakes, the following domain-specific reconstruction patterns are hypothesized:

Compressed Domain	Reconstruction Direction	Example
Shame	Ambiguity reconstructed as external attack or humiliation	“They were trying to embarrass me”
Dependency	Closeness reconstructed as control or engulfment	“They were trying to trap me”
Abandonment	Uncertainty reconstructed as rejection or betrayal	“They were planning to leave”
Status	Criticism reconstructed as malicious degradation	“They were trying to destroy my reputation”
Control	Autonomy of others reconstructed as chaos or threat	“Everything is falling apart because of them”
Vulnerability	Emotional exposure reconstructed as weakness exploitation	“They used my openness against me”

These patterns are proposed as structural hypotheses, not established findings. They require empirical validation.

4.4 Prediction: Intra-Individual Domain Specificity

A critical prediction follows from the directionality hypothesis: the same individual should show different reconstruction patterns across different signal classes.

A person with high compression in dependency but low compression in professional status should: - Reconstruct relational ambiguity toward control/engulfment interpretations - Maintain relatively accurate representation of professional feedback

This intra-individual domain specificity distinguishes SRF’s account from global trait-based explanations of distortion (e.g., general paranoia, global self-serving bias). The prediction is that reconstruction is selective, not uniform.

5. Feedback Integration Capacity

5.1 Definition

Feedback Integration Capacity (FIC) is defined as the capacity to receive external information about one's own regulatory architecture and update the internal self-model accordingly.

FIC is distinct from: - **Insight** (which implies introspective access - opacity may make this unreliable) - **Openness to experience** (which is a trait, not a structural capacity) - **Mentalization** (which concerns understanding others' minds, not receiving information about one's own architecture)

5.2 Multi-Stage Process

FIC is proposed to operate through a multi-stage process:

1. **Reception:** External feedback enters the system (e.g., "You always withdraw when...")
2. **Signal classification:** The system classifies the feedback content (this concerns my dependency pattern)
3. **Threat assessment:** The system evaluates whether integrating this feedback threatens self-coherence
4. **Holding:** If threat is manageable, the system holds the feedback without immediate discharge
5. **Model update:** The self-model incorporates the new information

FIC can fail at any stage: - Stage 1: Feedback not received (avoidance, dismissal, attentional filtering) - Stage 2: Feedback misclassified (experienced as attack rather than information) - Stage 3: Threat exceeds holding capacity, triggering compression - Stage 4: Holding fails, feedback discharged through externalization - Stage 5: Model update blocked by self-architecture rigidity

5.3 The Recursive Feedback Trap

A central clinical problem emerges from the interaction between FIC and compression:

1. Feedback about a compressed domain enters through that domain
2. The domain is compressed precisely because its content is threatening
3. Therefore feedback about the domain is experienced as threat
4. Threat activates compression
5. Compression reduces resolution of the feedback itself
6. Reduced resolution distorts interpretation of the feedback
7. Distorted interpretation becomes defensive response
8. Defensive response blocks integration

This recursive trap explains why "just telling someone" rarely produces structural change. The delivery channel is the problem channel. Feedback about compressed domains must pass through the very compression it seeks to address.

5.4 FIC as Partially Independent from IRC

A reductive account would propose that FIC simply equals IRC plus low compression in the relevant domain. Under this account, no new construct is needed.

However, FIC may capture something that IRC alone does not - the specific capacity for self-model updating. Two individuals with equivalent IRC and equivalent compression may differ in how readily they update their self-model when feedback penetrates. This additional variance may reflect:

- **Epistemic trust** (Fonagy et al., 2015): willingness to treat others as reliable information sources about oneself
- **Self-model flexibility**: how rigid versus revisable the current self-representation is
- **Meta-cognitive capacity**: ability to hold “my perception may be structurally limited” as a live hypothesis

The degree of FIC independence from IRC and compression remains an empirical question. The present paper proposes FIC as a potentially useful construct while acknowledging that its discriminant validity requires empirical demonstration.

5.5 Therapy as FIC-Enabling Condition

If FIC is the primary mechanism of structural learning, then therapy is not primarily insight delivery. It is:

Externally scaffolded self-model revision under conditions of sufficient holding.

The therapeutic relationship may function as an FIC-enabling condition by providing: - Repeated, consistent feedback (data accumulation across sessions) - Relational safety (reduces threat assessment at Stage 3) - Holding augmentation (scaffolds IRC for Stage 4) - Timing (delivers feedback when activation is manageable) - Persistence (maintains feedback across the recursive trap’s resistance)

This reframes therapeutic alliance not merely as a “warm relationship” but as a structural condition that enables self-model updating within domains that would otherwise remain inaccessible to revision.

6. Structural Opacity

6.1 Definition

Structural Opacity refers to the degree to which a compressed signal class is unavailable to direct self-observation from within the system that produces it.

Compression does not merely reduce resolution of external signals. It may also reduce the system’s capacity to observe its own compression. A compressed signal class does not appear internally as “distorted” - it appears as reality. The architecture disappears into the subjective world it generates.

6.2 Opacity as Derived Consequence

Structural Opacity is proposed as a derived consequence of compression, not as an independent foundational construct.

The mechanism is straightforward: 1. Self-observation requires representational resources 2. Representational resources in a compressed domain are, by definition, reduced 3. Therefore the system cannot represent its own compression at full resolution 4. The compressed interpretation becomes the only available interpretation

This is not denial (motivated avoidance of known truth). It is structural - the system may lack the representational bandwidth to perceive its own bandwidth limitation.

The conservative position is that opacity does not require its own construct - it is a logical entailment of compression. However, explicit articulation is necessary because opacity has major clinical and theoretical implications that are not obvious from the compression construct alone.

6.3 Why Updating Fails Phenomenologically

Structural Opacity connects directly to the FIC limitations described in Section 5. Opacity explains why feedback integration fails at the phenomenological level:

- The individual cannot perceive that their processing is compressed
- Therefore they cannot perceive that their interpretation may be reconstructed
- Therefore external feedback appears to contradict their direct experience
- Therefore feedback is experienced as inaccurate, hostile, or manipulative

This is not stubbornness or defensiveness in the motivational sense. It is a structural limitation: the system genuinely cannot access the higher-fidelity representation that would make the feedback comprehensible.

6.4 Signal-Class Specificity of Opacity

Opacity is hypothesized to be signal-class-specific. The same individual may show:

- High transparency in professional domains (can observe own ambition, competitiveness)
- Moderate opacity in control domains (notices rigidity but attributes it to “high standards”)
- High opacity in dependency domains (experiences defended independence as genuine preference)
- Near-complete opacity in shame domains (experiences shame avoidance as justified self-protection)

This signal-class specificity is a direct prediction of the compression topology model (Paper 4; Halmetoja, 2026d). Opacity should be highest in the most severely compressed domains.

6.5 Self-Report Unreliability in Opaque Domains

A methodological implication follows: self-report instruments may systematically underestimate compression in high-opacity domains. If the construct predicts that individuals cannot accurately perceive their own compression, then self-report measures of that compression face a fundamental validity challenge.

This does not make measurement impossible, but it constrains measurement approaches. Candidate methods that may circumvent opacity include: - Self-other discrepancy measures (comparing self-report with informant report) - Implicit-explicit divergence paradigms - Behavioral indicators rather than self-report - Longitudinal tracking of self-model revision under therapeutic conditions

6.6 Opacity-FIC Interaction Matrix

The interaction between Structural Opacity and Feedback Integration Capacity produces four clinically distinct presentations:

Opacity	FIC	Clinical Presentation
Low	High	Person sees own patterns and can learn from feedback. Fastest growth trajectory.
Low	Low	Person sees own patterns but cannot update behavior. “I know I do this but I cannot stop.”
High	High	Person cannot see own patterns but can learn from external mirrors. Therapy-responsive.

Opacity	FIC	Clinical Presentation
High	Low	Person cannot see own patterns AND cannot integrate feedback. Most treatment-resistant.

The High Opacity / High FIC combination is particularly noteworthy: these individuals may not have introspective access to their compressed domains, but they can learn from accumulated relational evidence. Their self-awareness is socially scaffolded rather than introspectively generated.

The High Opacity / Low FIC combination describes the clinical picture often labeled “lack of insight” or “treatment resistance.” SRF reframes this: it is not motivational failure but structural limitation at two levels simultaneously.

7. Relationship to Existing Literature

7.1 Motivated Reasoning

Kunda (1990) established that motivation can bias reasoning processes. People arrive at conclusions they want to arrive at, constrained only by their ability to construct justifications.

SRF’s proposed contribution beyond motivated reasoning: - **Structural specificity:** SRF proposes that the direction of bias follows compression topology, not merely motivation. The same motivation (self-protection) produces different distortions depending on which signal classes are compressed. - **Capacity rather than motivation:** SRF reframes distortion as emerging from representational overload rather than from motivated goal pursuit. The individual may not be “trying” to reach a preferred conclusion - they may be structurally unable to sustain the alternative. - **Domain selectivity:** Motivated reasoning is typically modeled as a general process. SRF predicts that the same individual shows different reconstruction patterns across different signal classes.

7.2 Cognitive Dissonance

Festinger (1957) proposed that inconsistency between cognitions produces discomfort that motivates resolution. SRF’s relationship to dissonance theory:

- **Convergence:** Both frameworks propose that inconsistency drives cognitive reorganization
- **Divergence:** Dissonance theory does not specify why certain inconsistencies are more threatening than others. SRF proposes that threat level depends on self-architecture stakes and signal-class compression depth.
- **Extension:** SRF offers a structural account of why some individuals show extreme dissonance reduction (high compression + high stakes) while others tolerate contradiction (high IRC + low compression in the relevant domain).

7.3 Reconstructive Memory

Bartlett (1932), Loftus (1979, 2005), and Schacter (1996, 2001) established that memory is reconstructive rather than reproductive. Memory is continuously rebuilt through schemas, expectations, and current context.

SRF does not challenge this foundation. Its proposed contribution is narrower:

- **Directional explanation:** Traditional reconstructive memory theory explains that memory is rebuilt. SRF proposes why reconstruction becomes selectively biased within specific domains of psychological threat.
- **Architecture-constrained direction:** SRF proposes that reconstruction direction follows compression topology and self-architecture stakes - not merely general schemas or current mood.
- **Regulatory function:** SRF proposes that defensive reconstruction specifically serves regulatory stability, distinguishing it from neutral schema-driven reconstruction.

7.4 Self-Deception Literature

The self-deception literature (Trivers, 2011; von Hippel & Trivers, 2011) proposes that humans deceive themselves to more effectively deceive others, or to maintain positive self-image.

SRF offers a different framing: - **Capacity rather than strategy:** Self-deception in SRF is not a strategy (even an unconscious one). It is a structural consequence of representational overload. The individual does not “choose” to deceive themselves - they may lack the holding capacity to sustain the alternative representation. - **Not adaptive deception:** SRF does not propose that reconstruction serves social deception. It proposes that reconstruction serves internal regulatory stability, regardless of social consequences.

7.5 Explicit Novelty Claims

The proposed novelty of the present paper lies in:

1. **Structural rather than purely motivational explanation** for directional distortion
2. **Signal-class-specific reconstruction vulnerability** - distortion follows compression topology
3. **Explicit linkage** between compression, holding capacity, and reconstruction direction
4. **Integration with self-architecture and regulatory stakes** - explaining why specific truths become unsustainable for specific individuals
5. **Formalization of the compression-to-reconstruction transition** as a threshold phenomenon (cost > IRC)
6. **Derived constructs** (Structural Opacity, FIC) that generate testable predictions about therapy responsiveness and measurement validity

8. Predictions and Testability

8.1 Reconstruction Direction Follows Compression Profile

Prediction: Individuals with high compression in a specific signal class will show reconstruction patterns consistent with that domain’s characteristic direction (see Section 4.3 table). Individuals with low compression in the same domain will show less directional reconstruction.

Candidate test: Assess compression profiles (Paper 4 instrument, when available), then present ambiguous interpersonal vignettes and measure interpretation direction. Interpretation should correlate with domain-specific compression, not with global distortion tendency.

8.2 Self-Other Discrepancy Is Domain-Specific

Prediction: The discrepancy between self-report and informant-report should be larger in highly compressed signal classes and smaller in low-compression domains within the same individual.

Candidate test: Multi-informant assessment across signal classes. A person with high dependency compression should show large self-other discrepancy on dependency-related items but small discrepancy on professional competence items (assuming low compression in that domain).

8.3 FIC Predicts Therapy Responsiveness

Prediction: Individuals with higher FIC (even with high opacity) should show greater self-model revision across therapy compared to individuals with low FIC.

Candidate test: Longitudinal tracking of self-model change across therapy sessions. FIC could be assessed through standardized feedback integration tasks at intake. Therapy outcome should correlate with FIC after controlling for symptom severity and therapeutic alliance.

8.4 Collapse Progression Is Sequential

Prediction: Under increasing activation, the collapse from selective compression to Ontological Binary Encoding should follow a sequential progression (Stages 1-4) rather than occurring as a single discontinuous shift.

Candidate test: Ecological momentary assessment during periods of relational stress. Track whether domain-specific compression (Stage 1) precedes cross-domain coupling (Stage 2) precedes signal-class convergence (Stage 3) precedes ontological encoding (Stage 4).

8.5 Candidate Measurement Approaches

Construct	Measurement Challenge	Candidate Approach
Compression Profile	Self-report unreliable in compressed domains	Multi-informant + implicit measures
Reconstruction Direction	Cannot directly observe internal process	Ambiguous vignette interpretation paradigms
Structural Opacity	Construct predicts self-report invalidity	Self-other discrepancy magnitude
FIC	Requires longitudinal observation	Standardized feedback integration tasks
Collapse Progression	Requires real-time tracking under stress	Ecological momentary assessment

9. Collapse Progression: From Selective Compression to Ontological Binary Encoding

This section proposes a four-stage model of progressive regulatory collapse. This model is the most speculative component of the present paper and should be understood as a candidate framework requiring empirical validation.

9.1 Stage 1: Selective Compression

The initial stage involves domain-specific compression as described in Paper 4 (Halmetoja, 2026d). A specific signal class experiences reduced representational resolution under activation. Other domains may continue functioning at higher resolution.

At this stage: - Compression is localized - The individual may function well in unaffected domains - Reconstruction occurs within the compressed domain but does not generalize - External observers may notice domain-specific rigidity or distortion

9.2 Stage 2: Cross-Domain Coupling

Under sustained or intensifying activation, compression may begin spreading across signal-class boundaries. Domains that were previously independent begin activating together.

At this stage: - Shame activation may trigger dependency compression - Rejection signals may activate status compression - Multiple domains begin compressing simultaneously - The individual's regulatory resources become increasingly strained - Reconstruction becomes more pervasive but may still show domain structure

9.3 Stage 3: Signal-Class Convergence

Under severe activation, domain boundaries may dissolve. Previously distinct signal classes begin converging into generalized threat encoding. The system no longer differentiates between types of threat - all activated content begins to feel like the same undifferentiated danger.

At this stage: - Criticism, autonomy, disagreement, distance, and boundaries may all register as equivalent threat - Nuanced relational meaning collapses - The individual may experience generalized persecution or generalized abandonment - Reconstruction becomes global rather than domain-specific

9.4 Stage 4: Ontological Binary Encoding

The terminal stage of collapse involves the reduction of multidimensional psychological reality into a minimal existential encoding:

Existence-confirming vs Existence-threatening

This connects directly to Paper 6 (Halmetoja, 2026f), which formalizes ontological regulation. At Stage 4, all meaning reduces to whether the current input confirms or threatens continuity of being.

At this stage: - All relational signals are processed through a single existential filter - Highly compressed dichotomous processing dominates - The individual may experience survival-level destabilization from minor relational events - Reconstruction becomes maximally distorted - all ambiguity resolves toward existential threat or existential confirmation - Recovery requires external stabilization before any representational work is possible

9.5 Clinical Examples

Stage 1 example: A person with high shame compression interprets neutral workplace feedback as criticism, but maintains accurate relational perception with friends.

Stage 2 example: Following a relational rupture, the same person begins experiencing both professional feedback AND social interactions as threatening. Shame and rejection domains activate together.

Stage 3 example: Under sustained relational stress, the person begins experiencing all interpersonal contact as potentially dangerous. Domain distinctions dissolve. "Everyone is against me" replaces domain-specific distortions.

Stage 4 example: During acute crisis, the person experiences all input through a single filter: “Does this confirm that I exist and matter, or does it threaten my psychological survival?” A partner’s request for space becomes indistinguishable from existential annihilation.

10. Clinical Implications

10.1 Why Confrontation Fails

The combination of Structural Opacity and the recursive feedback trap creates a structural explanation for why direct confrontation often fails in clinical work with highly compressed architectures:

1. The individual cannot perceive their own compression (opacity)
2. Feedback about compressed domains enters through those domains (recursive trap)
3. The feedback is therefore experienced as threat rather than information
4. Threat activates further compression
5. Further compression strengthens the reconstructed version
6. The confrontation paradoxically reinforces the distortion it sought to correct

This does not mean that confrontation is never appropriate. It means that confrontation without sufficient holding capacity augmentation may be structurally counterproductive.

10.2 Scaffolded Integration vs Forced Insight

Paper 2 (Halmetoja, 2026b) introduced scaffolded integration as the mechanism by which structural change becomes possible. The present paper extends this concept:

Forced insight: Delivering accurate information about the individual’s architecture without regard for current holding capacity. May trigger defensive reconstruction rather than integration.

Scaffolded integration: Gradually increasing holding capacity within the relevant signal domain while providing consistent, non-threatening feedback. Allows higher-fidelity representation to become tolerable before it is introduced.

The key clinical principle: the system must be able to hold what insight would reveal before insight can produce structural change.

10.3 Collapse Prevention vs Collapse Recovery

The collapse progression model (Section 9) suggests two distinct clinical tasks:

Collapse prevention: Intervening at Stages 1-2 before cross-domain coupling produces generalized destabilization. At these stages, domain-specific work may still be effective.

Collapse recovery: At Stages 3-4, domain-specific work may be impossible because domain boundaries have dissolved. Recovery may require: - External stabilization first (reducing activation below the convergence threshold) - Re-establishing domain boundaries before content work - Gradual re-differentiation of signal classes - Only then: domain-specific integration work

10.4 Therapeutic Alliance as FIC-Enabling Condition

The therapeutic alliance may function not merely as a “warm relationship” that makes therapy pleasant, but as a structural condition that enables Feedback Integration Capacity:

- **Safety reduces threat assessment:** Relational safety may lower the threshold at which feedback triggers compression (Stage 3 of FIC process)
- **Consistency provides data:** Repeated consistent feedback across sessions accumulates evidence that may eventually penetrate the recursive trap
- **Holding augmentation:** The therapist’s capacity to hold complexity may temporarily scaffold the client’s IRC
- **Timing:** An attuned therapist delivers feedback when activation is manageable, not when the system is already in collapse

This reframes alliance ruptures not merely as relational problems but as potential FIC disruptions - moments when the structural conditions for self-model updating are temporarily lost.

11. Limitations

11.1 Empirical Status

The present paper is entirely conceptual. No empirical validation has been conducted for any of the proposed constructs or mechanisms. Defensive reconstruction, Structural Opacity, Feedback Integration Capacity, and the collapse progression model remain theoretical proposals requiring empirical testing. The framework should be evaluated on its internal coherence, parsimony, and capacity to generate testable predictions - not on established empirical support, which does not yet exist.

11.2 Boundary with Motivated Cognition Literature

The overlap between defensive reconstruction and motivated reasoning (Kunda, 1990), cognitive dissonance (Festinger, 1957), and self-deception (Trivers, 2011) remains a significant concern. The proposed novelty (structural domain-specificity, capacity-based rather than motivation-based explanation, signal-class selectivity) requires empirical demonstration. It is possible that existing frameworks already account for the phenomena described here without requiring additional constructs.

11.3 Opacity Measurement Paradox

Structural Opacity creates a methodological challenge: if the construct predicts that self-report is unreliable in opaque domains, then direct measurement of opacity through self-report is problematic. This is not a fatal flaw - indirect measurement approaches exist (self-other discrepancy, implicit measures) - but it constrains the measurement architecture and increases the complexity of validation studies.

11.4 FIC Independence Question

Whether Feedback Integration Capacity represents a genuinely independent construct or reduces to IRC plus compression level remains an open empirical question. The present paper proposes FIC as potentially independent based on theoretical considerations (epistemic trust, self-model flexibility), but discriminant validity has not been demonstrated. It is possible that FIC adds no explanatory power beyond existing SRF constructs.

11.5 Collapse Progression: Sequential or Parallel?

The four-stage collapse model assumes sequential progression (Stage 1 precedes Stage 2 precedes Stage 3 precedes Stage 4). This assumption may be incorrect. Some individuals may show rapid transitions that skip intermediate stages. Others may show parallel activation of multiple stages simultaneously. The sequential model is proposed as a simplifying assumption that generates testable predictions, not as an established finding.

11.6 Generalizability

The present paper draws heavily on clinical observations from narcissistic and personality-disordered presentations. Whether defensive reconstruction operates similarly in other clinical populations (anxiety disorders, trauma presentations, psychotic processes) remains unexamined. The framework may be narrower in applicability than its general language suggests.

12. Conclusion

The first-generation SRF architecture (Papers 1-6) establishes compression as the primary mechanism through which representational resolution decreases under regulatory threat. Compression explains why reality becomes low-resolution within threatened signal domains.

The present paper proposes that compression alone may not fully account for clinical phenomena in which reality appears not merely simplified but specifically reorganized. Defensive reconstruction is proposed as a second-order process: when the representational cost of maintaining higher-fidelity integration exceeds current holding capacity, the system may reshape accessible subjective reality to preserve regulatory coherence.

This is not merely seeing less. It is seeing something else.

The direction of reconstruction is hypothesized to follow compression topology and self-architecture stakes - producing domain-specific distortion patterns rather than uniform bias. This structural specificity is the central novelty claim distinguishing the present account from existing motivated cognition frameworks.

Two derived constructs - Structural Opacity and Feedback Integration Capacity - are proposed to explain why compressed and reconstructed domains resist correction. Opacity explains why the individual cannot perceive their own distortion. FIC explains why some individuals can nevertheless learn from external feedback while others cannot.

A four-stage collapse progression model is proposed for severe presentations: from selective compression through cross-domain coupling and signal-class convergence to Ontological Binary Encoding - the terminal state in which all meaning reduces to whether current input confirms or threatens continuity of being.

These proposals remain entirely conceptual. Their value depends on whether they generate predictions that survive empirical testing. The framework is proposed as a structural hypothesis - one possible interpretation of clinical phenomena that may prove useful, incomplete, or incorrect upon contact with empirical reality.

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